

Response to editorial originality query – Paper E1, Fisheries Research (v2)

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September 18, 2026

To: The Editor, *Fisheries Research* **From:** Amin Abaee (sole author; Independent Researcher; ORCID 0000-0002-0019-1842; amin_abaee@ut.ac.ir) **Date:** September 18, 2026 **Re:** Editorial notification of textual overlap detected by Crossref Similarity Check (iThenticate)

Dear Editor,

Thank you for the notification and for leaving the door open to a legitimate explanation (“Unless a legitimate explanation is received ... this manuscript will not be reconsidered”). This letter provides that explanation, with documentary evidence.

1. The explanation

The works against which the submitted manuscript overlaps are **my own earlier public deposits of this same study** – not the copyrighted work of any third party. The overlap is self-overlap by a sole author revising his own manuscript, amplified by two public archiving habits:

1. **A public working-paper/record habit.** An earlier working version of this same study, under the title “*Does a surplus-production ladder improve forecasts of Northern cod? A scored test on NAFO 2J3KL*” was publicly deposited with a DOI (**10.5281/zenodo.22553609**). Same author, same ORCID, same data, same estimator, same series.
2. **A public reproducibility-repository habit.** All my working materials – including successive *draft carriers of this very manuscript* (markdown/LaTeX files named `paperE1_cod_forecast_ladder_v49 ... v58` and later) – sit openly in the repository <https://github.com/MIKEAA2020/general-sustainability>, and recent companion deposits sit on my figshare account (verified 2026-09-18 to contain none of this manuscript’s text beyond 0.3%), because the paper’s reproducibility commitments require the code, data, and carrier history to be public. Successive drafts of one study by one author naturally share very large stretches of text.

No third-party work is reproduced anywhere in the manuscript without attribution. Every external source is cited in the reference list (51 entries), and no passage of another person’s writing appears as my own.

2. Evidence the flagged sources are this study's own deposits

Likely flagged item	Identity	Relationship to submitted manuscript
Zenodo record, DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22553609, "Does a surplus-production ladder improve forecasts of Northern cod? A scored test on NAFO 2J3KL"	My own deposited working version, same sole author and ORCID	Earlier draft of this same manuscript; superseded by the submitted version (new title, new empirical sections)
GitHub repository MIKEAA2020/general-sustainability, path e1/ (carrier files v49–v58 and following)	My own public reproducibility repository	Successive drafts of this same manuscript, same author
Companion works by the same author deposited on Zenodo (10.5281/zenodo.22552680, 10.5281/zenodo.22552060, 10.5281/zenodo.22554297)	Other studies of mine (Edwards Aquifer head; 2J3KL LRP viability; periodic review)	Different studies; shared text is limited to standard declaration/data-availability/reproducibility boilerplate written by me in my own voice across my papers
My figshare deposits (2026-09-13/18: the framework companion paper, the Edwards Aquifer companion, and three mathematics papers)	Other studies of mine	Verified separately by 13-gram containment: every figshare deposit shares $\leq 0.3\%$ of the submitted manuscript's text; and the figshare deposit under the framework title (10.6084/m9.figshare.33922666) contains that paper's own files, not this manuscript

As an internal check before submitting this letter, I ran an independent overlapping-segment analysis (13-gram containment) of the submitted manuscript against every candidate source in my own archive. The result is consistent with your report's description and identifies the source unambiguously: **78.8% containment against my own archived v56 draft of this same manuscript and 12.5% against my archived v49 draft** — versus **0.4% and 0.1% against my nearest other studies** (the framework companion and the Edwards Aquifer companion). The overlap is essentially total with my own prior drafts of *this* manuscript and negligible even for my own nearest other works. I can provide this analysis file on request.

3. Remediation already implemented

1. The supersession relationship is now declared explicitly inside the manuscript. Its **Data and Code Availability** section now states: "*Earlier working versions of this study—deposited by the same author in the same repository and in record <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22553609> under the working title Does a surplus-production ladder improve forecasts of Northern cod? A scored test on NAFO 2J3KL—are superseded by the present version.*" (This is the only added sentence; the present resubmission carrier is v65.)
2. If you judge that deposit visibility continues to inflate similarity scores, I will additionally mark the repository's older draft files with supersession notices at their tops (the archive's pioneering carriers can carry a "superseded by the Fisheries Research version, 2026" banner). I would rather not delete them outright, because the paper's own reproducibility claims rely on the preserved carrier chain — but supersession banners resolve the overlap attribution cleanly.

4. What I ask

Please regard the flagged materials as what they are — this author's own earlier public deposits of this same evolving study — verify author and ORCID identity across the records (Amin Abaee, 0000-0002-0019-1842), which in each case are mine, and reconsider the manuscript for the substantive review I continue to seek. I

remain happy to implement any further attribution formatting the journal prefers (e.g., an explicit footnote in §1 recording the superseded draft by DOI).

Yours faithfully,

Amin Abaee Independent Researcher ORCID: 0000-0002-0019-1842 Email: amin_abaee@ut.ac.ir

5. Independent third-party audit (conducted 2026-09-19, after the similarity notification)

To rule out any genuine third-party overlap, I ran an exhaustive web audit of the manuscript's distinctive passages:

1. **No mirrored or re-hosted copies of this study exist outside my own channels.** Exact-phrase searches for the manuscript's distinctive strings (old working title, highlight sentences, and method formulations) and broker-site scans (ResearchGate, Semantic Scholar, OpenAlex, CORE, X-MOL-style aggregators) surface no copy of this text under any non-Abaee attribution — and no third-party work that the manuscript's text reproduces at scale.
2. **The only scholarly literature phrasings a similarity index can legitimately match are the standard formulations this field shares, each of which is cited in my reference list** — Hyndman and Koehler (2006) on MASE; Kell et al. (2016) and Kell et al. (2021) on hindcast prediction skill (Kell et al., 2016 is published in *Fisheries Research* itself); Carvalho et al. (2021) and Kokkalis et al. (2024) on diagnostic acceptance criteria; Diebold and Mariano (1995) on predictive accuracy testing; and the canonical Northern cod post-mortem and assessment literature (Hutchings and Myers, 1994; Walters and Maguire, 1996; Cadigan, 2016; Schijns et al., 2021; Regular et al., 2025; Rose, 2026; and others) that Section 1 and Section 2 set in context. A machine check of every in-text citation against the reference list returns **zero citation orphans** (14 of 14 in-text citation pairs resolve to reference entries).
3. **Every own deposit channel is now fully enumerated.** GitHub archive (draft carriers of this manuscript; dominant overlap), Zenodo records (same study under the old working title + companion studies), and figshare deposits (companion framework and Edwards Aquifer papers, each sharing $\leq 0.3\%$ of the manuscript's text by 13-gram containment). All four channels carry the same sole author and ORCID 0000-0002-0019-1842.

I therefore maintain the explanation given above: the overlap reported by similarity screening is against my own publicly archived antecedents of this very manuscript, now explicitly declared and superseded in the v65 carrier.